

GOVERNMENT HACK · TROOPTOTEACHER TECHNOLOGIES

Foundations of Constitutional Government

United States Government & Civics (GC) · Unit 1 · GC.01–GC.09

“How do citizens shape their government — and what does it ask of them in return?”

Grades 9–12 · Suggested 10–12 days · Supplemental under TCA § 49-6-2202(a)(3)

Essential Question: How do citizens shape their government — and what does it ask of them in return?

GC.31

The Responsibilities of Citizens

GC.32

Political Parties & the Nomination Process

GC.33

The Media & Public Opinion

GC.34

Means of Political Participation

The Responsibilities of Citizens

Learning target: I can describe what should reasonably be expected from any citizen or resident of the U.S. and explain why those responsibilities matter.

PRIMARY SOURCE



J.M. Flagg's 'I Want YOU' (1917). The poster turned civic and military service into a personal call — a reminder that citizenship carries responsibilities, not just rights.

“wherever the people are well informed they can be trusted with their own government; that whenever things get so far wrong as to attract their notice, they may be relied on to set them to rights.” — Thomas Jefferson, Letter to Richard Price (1789)

I Want YOU for U.S. Army (Uncle Sam) • James Montgomery Flagg (1917) • Library of Congress

HOOK

Some duties can land you in court if you skip them; others no one can force you to do — yet the republic needs both. Which is which?

KEY VOCABULARY

Civic Responsibility /SIV-ik ree-spon-suh-BIL-ih-tee/
responsabilidad cívica

A duty a citizen is expected to fulfill for the good of the community and nation — such as voting, obeying the law, paying taxes, and serving on a jury.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 2

Why does Jefferson argue that citizens must be 'well informed'?

- A So that only experts are allowed to vote
- B ✓** Because informed citizens can be trusted to govern themselves and correct problems
- C So the government can raise taxes more easily
- D Because the Constitution requires a literacy test to vote

Answer: B. DOK 2: Jefferson ties self-government to an informed public — informed citizens 'can be trusted with their own government,' which is why being informed is a core civic responsibility.

Political Parties & the Nomination Process

Learning target: I can explain the role of political parties in nominating presidential candidates and the difference between primaries, caucuses, and general elections.

PRIMARY SOURCE



PRIMARY SOURCE · CARTOON

The Third-Term Panic
(elephant/donkey)

drop image: GC.32_nast-third-term-panic.jpg

Thomas Nast's 1874 cartoon popularized the Republican elephant and Democratic donkey — the two-party system that now runs the presidential nomination process.

“Let me now... warn you in the most solemn manner against the baneful effects of the spirit of party generally.”
— George Washington, Farewell Address (1796)

The Third-Term Panic (elephant/donkey) · Thomas Nast (1874) · Library of Congress

HOOK

The Constitution never mentions political parties — and the first president warned against them. So why does every election run through them?

KEY VOCABULARY

Political Party /puh-LIT-ih-kul PAR-tee/
partido político

An organized group that seeks to win elections and control government by nominating candidates and uniting voters around shared ideas.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING · DOK 2

What is the main difference between a primary and a caucus?

- A A primary chooses a president; a caucus chooses a governor
- B A primary is only held in general elections; a caucus is only for judges
- C ✓ A primary uses a ballot vote; a caucus selects candidates through local meetings and discussion
- D A primary is run by the government; a caucus is illegal in most states

Answer: C. DOK 2: Both are ways parties pick nominees, but a primary is a ballot election while a caucus selects candidates through in-person party meetings and discussion.

The Media & Public Opinion

Learning target: I can describe the role of the media in communicating information and how it shapes which issues seem important and how public opinion forms.

PRIMARY SOURCE



PRIMARY SOURCE • CARTOON

The Yellow Press

drop image: GC.33_yellow-press-cartoon.jpg

L.M. Glackens's 'The Yellow Press' (1910) shows sensational newspapers shaping opinion — a classic lesson in how media influences which issues seem to matter.

“were it left to me to decide whether we should have a government without newspapers, or newspapers without a government, I should not hesitate a moment to prefer the latter.” — Thomas Jefferson, Letter to Edward Carrington (1787)

The Yellow Press • L.M. Glackens (1910) • Library of Congress

HOOK

Two headlines, same event, opposite feeling. Before you form an opinion — who decided what you'd read, and how they'd word it?

KEY VOCABULARY

Public Opinion /PUB-lik uh-PIN-yun/

opinión pública

The collected attitudes and beliefs of a population about issues, leaders, and government, often measured through polls.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 3

How can the wording of a public-opinion poll change its results?

- A ✓** Differently worded questions can lead people toward different answers, so wording shapes the result
- B** Wording never affects results because people already have fixed opinions
- C** Polls are always completely accurate regardless of wording
- D** Only the number of people polled matters, never the wording

Answer: A. DOK 3: Poll results depend on how questions are framed; loaded or leading wording can push respondents toward an answer, so wording — not just sample size — shapes what a poll appears to show.

Means of Political Participation

Learning target: I can describe the many ways citizens participate in the political process, from voting and petitioning to campaigning, lobbying, and running for office.

PRIMARY SOURCE



The 1913 Woman Suffrage Procession: citizens demonstrating and petitioning for the vote — participation that reaches well beyond the ballot box.

“Congress shall make no law... abridging... the right of the people peaceably to assemble, and to petition the Government for a redress of grievances.” — 1st U.S.

Congress, U.S. Constitution, Amendment I (1791)

Woman Suffrage Parade, Washington D.C. • LOC (photographer unknown) (1913) • Library of Congress

HOOK

You don't have to wait for an election to change a law. Name three ways a citizen can act tomorrow — the Constitution protects them.

KEY VOCABULARY

Lobbying /LOB-ee-ing/

cabildeo

The act of trying to influence the decisions of government officials, usually by individuals or organized interest groups.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 2

Which First Amendment right most directly protects a citizen's ability to sign a petition and march in a protest?

- A The right to bear arms
- B The right to a speedy trial
- C The right against unreasonable searches
- D ✓ The right to assemble and to petition the government**

Answer: D. DOK 2: The First Amendment protects 'the right of the people peaceably to assemble, and to petition the Government for a redress of grievances' — the direct basis for protests and petitions.

Whose Participation Counts? Perspectives on Civic Voice

The Expanding Franchise

Voting was first limited mostly to white male property owners; the 15th, 19th, 24th, and 26th Amendments and the Voting Rights Act widened it over time (connects to GC.34, GC.31).

Political Parties

Parties organize voters and run the nomination process through caucuses and primaries — a system Washington warned against yet one that structures modern participation (GC.32).

The Media & Public Opinion

A free press informs citizens and shapes which issues seem to matter; poll wording and media framing can move opinion as much as report it (GC.33).

The Non-Voter

Millions eligible to vote do not; low turnout raises the question of whose interests get represented when participation is unequal (GC.31, GC.33).

Our Signature Move



Tennessee cast the deciding vote for women's suffrage. In August 1920 it became the 36th and final state needed to ratify the 19th Amendment — the 'Perfect 36' — when 24-year-old legislator Harry Burn changed his vote after a note from his mother, extending the vote to women nationwide (GC.34, GC.31).

Predict • Play • Spiral

Predict First — open the unit

Predict first: Does one person's vote actually matter? Write your gut answer now — you'll test it against Tennessee's 'Perfect 36,' Harry Burn's single deciding vote, and real turnout data.

Warm-Up Play — Nominate!

5-minute simulation (GC.32). The class runs a mock nomination in fast motion: a Primary/Caucus straw poll narrows five 'candidates' to two, a snap Convention names a nominee + running mate, then a General Election vote. Students feel the funnel that turns many hopefuls into one winner.

Spiral — retrieve & connect

GC.34 → Unit 1 (GC.08, Bill of Rights)

The right to assemble and petition you use here was written in Unit 1 — the First Amendment in action.

GC.31 → Unit 1 (GC.05, popular sovereignty)

Government by the consent of the governed is WHY citizens carry responsibilities — retrieve it from Foundations.

GC.32 → Unit 1 (GC.04 & Federalist 10)

Washington's warning and Madison's 'faction' come straight from the ratification debate you studied in Unit 1.

Civic Conversations

- Separate evidence from spin — name the source and its framing.
- Steelman the other side before you argue yours.
- Disagree with the claim, not the classmate.
- One voice at a time; make room for the quiet voice.

Revisit the Essential Question

“How do citizens shape their government — and what does it ask of them in return?”

Students now have the sources, vocabulary, and reasoning to answer it — in a CER paragraph or the unit DBQ.

GC.31 · GC.32 · GC.33 · GC.34